

Hartford School
District & Dartmouth
College (ENGS 15.11)

11/19/25

Belonging from the Start:
Designing a Framework
for Welcoming
Multilingual Students

Discover/Interpret Slide-Deck

Interview with S11:

Throughout our research, we interviewed students in varying stages of English proficiency and status in the ELL program. We found that younger students often had an easier time adapting to school norms and finding community within school, the same could not be said for some of the older students we spoke to.

One High School student only moved to the United States two years ago. They first went to a High School nearby where they made friends who also spoke her language and were in the ELL program with her. Speaking her language in school helped her establish a sense of normality and belonging in a new environment. They started this year at Hartford High School where they state they has no other peers to speak their language with.

They confided in their interviewer that they never felt completely comfortable in their new school. They couldn't communicate in either of their other languages at school, not to students or educators or even her ML teacher. They felt a sense of exhaustion having to speak and be around English all the time. They did not have an outlet until they went home and that made school feel like a chore instead of the place of belonging it should feel like.

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Contact List

- Undergraduate Team Members
- Dartmouth Contacts

Thank You!

Meet the Team!

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Meet the Team!

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Project Overview

Project Challenge

Within the past two years, the Hartford School District (HSD) community co-created their Vision of a Graduate, outlining the responsibility of educators to “prepare Hartford graduates to manage their health, explore career paths, build relationships, and excel academically.”

Research shows that experiences that foster identity and belonging affect long-term academic success; therefore, ensuring ELL students’ sense of belonging is crucial to supporting them in the ways they need to be successful at HSD and beyond.

Our challenge is to understand the ELL student experience and develop a plan for how to provide them an immediate sense of belonging in their first few months at HSD.

Key Questions

How might we help support students in the English as a Learned Language (ELL) program to immediately feel belonging in the culture and goals outlined in the HSD Vision of a Graduate?

How might we make communication across language barriers feel more personal?

How might we find opportunities for students to engage in their non-English language/culture at school?

Discovery Activities

Discovery Activities

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Co-Creation Session 1

For the first session we engaged with the following stakeholders in an idea generation activity and discussion:

- Dartmouth Team Members: 5
- District Team Members: 3
- Additional Educators: 6

Stakeholder Interviews

For additional 1-on-1 interviews we engaged with the following stakeholders:

- Middle School Interviews: 5*
- High School Interviews: 6*
- Additional Stakeholders: 11

*Students were interviewed in whatever language made them the most comfortable including English, Spanish, and Portuguese.

Co-Creation Session 2

For the second session we engaged with the following stakeholders in a mapping activity and discussion:

- Dartmouth Team Members: 7
- District Team Members: 3
- Additional Educators: 3

10/27/25

Our 1st Co-Creation Session focused on understanding the following:

- How do multilingual learners experience their first few months in a new school community, and what factors shape their sense of belonging and inclusion?
- How do teachers and administrators understand and navigate their roles in welcoming and supporting multilingual learners, and what supports or barriers influence their capacity to do so?
- How do school structures and staff relationships affect efforts to build an inclusive environment for multilingual learners?

Together we participated in a gallery walk, reading prompts written on poster paper hanging around the room, and added thoughts, ideas, and stories to each. After, everyone had the opportunity to share their experiences with the prompts and any thoughts that arose during the activity.

Co-Creation Session 1

Gallery Walk pt. 1

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Participants filled the posters with a variety of thoughts, feelings, and stories.

What are the biggest challenges you've faced supporting multilingual learners?

Integration of brand new ELL students into a mainstream classroom, trying to make sure they feel welcome and understand some part of what is happening in the classroom environment.

My own abilities
"Communication"

Trouble
contacting families

language
barrier -
communication

Communication
with child &
family

Not being
trained/provided with a
curriculum (this was
way before the www!)

limited
resources
(materials, ppl,
community,
etc.)

Building
trust with
families

few
systems
in place

supporting
families to
navigate the
systems in the
U.S./VT

only 2 ELL
educators
across 5
schools

Dependent on
MLL teachers
only -- (the
students belong
to ALL of us)

The various other
challenges facing students
& families (benefits, status,
transportation...)

What do you see as the biggest barriers to improving the ELL experience?

Lack of
foreign
language
learning in
schools

Not enough
resources or
diversity

ways to
authentically
communicate
with families

2
dedicated
staff in the
district

lack of exposure by
staff = resistance or
reluctance or
hesitancy

resources -
also not sure what
we actually need

few educators
in the district
with ELL
pedagogy
training

isolation
of
students

hyper
masculinity

lack of math
instruction
options for
students with
knowledge gaps

best methods to reach
parents? do they feel
comfortable communicating
with school?

conformity to
social norms
which might
"other" people

language
barrier

Lack of
interpretation
/translation
resources in
VT

Diversity
is
lacking

Where have you seen or heard students struggle most in their first few months? (Culturally, socially, academically, ect.)

exhaustion -> physical, social,
emotional.
It's so vulnerable to speak
another language in front of
others!

culturally --
different
foods @
lunch

Registration
+ other
paperwork

barriers
to
soccer

academically
-- reading &
writing

students who speak the
same language being silent
until they are around one or
more students from their
country

isolation
from other
non MLL
students

socially/
culturally
knowing what
to do & when

Extra
attention if
they look
"different"

communication
with home

systems
that make
no sense

Co-Creation Session 1

Gallery Walk pt. 2

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Participants filled the posters with a variety of thoughts, feelings, and stories.

What makes you most excited about having multilingual classrooms?

- Inclusion
- new perspectives
- growth of non-MLL folks

diversity!

diversity!
Appreciation of language!

exposure to new ways of living
- food
- music
- recreation
- dance
- language
- customs

learning between students (the unspoken curriculum)

strong work ethics

appreciation/value of a good education

diversity = broaden perspective

different perspectives

What makes you most nervous about having multilingual classrooms?

not supporting enough

are students getting what they need?
How do we know?

more work

communication

feeling like a failure, like I haven't included them

letting them and their families down (who have sacrificed a lot)

What are the biggest opportunities for ELL students to feel included & supported?

visible symbols that represent their culture, home country
- books, flags, etc.

learn new topics together

our curriculum can highlight MLL and their contributions

include their stories, cultures, and strengths that they bring

play & games

- curriculum inclusion
- finding commonalities

how we communicate that doesn't have to do with having a common language

fun/play!
(sports, theater, extracurriculars)

do activities that you know are strengths of the ELL student

a sense of patience and a "warm embrace" from English-only speaking peers

use peers to support new students

Student Interviews

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We interviewed 5 middle school ELL students in-person. Students were at different levels of English fluency and spoke the following languages:

- Portuguese
- Thai
- Chinese
- Spanish

We interviewed 6 high school ELL students in-person. Students were at different levels of English fluency and spoke the following languages:

- Portuguese
- Arabic
- Spanish

The most common themes from our conversations were:

Teachers rarely contact parents. If they do it's through email.

Loss of Culture

Sports/ Arts are Important

Friends are Important to feeling belonging

Teacher effort to translate doesn't go unnoticed

Students are close to their ML teachers

Stakeholder Interviews

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In our Stakeholder Interviews we met with the following:

- Assistant Superintendent
- District Social Worker
- ELL Educator
- PreK Coordinator
- PreK Title I Interventionist
- School Based Technician
- School Librarian
- School Principal (2)
- Teacher (2)

The most common themes in our conversations were:

Relationships Matter

Materials in Other Languages are Important

Teachers don't need to be experts

Just having something translated is key, software doesn't matter

In-Person Meetings with Parents are Preferred

11/13/25

Our 2nd Co-Creation Session focused on the following:

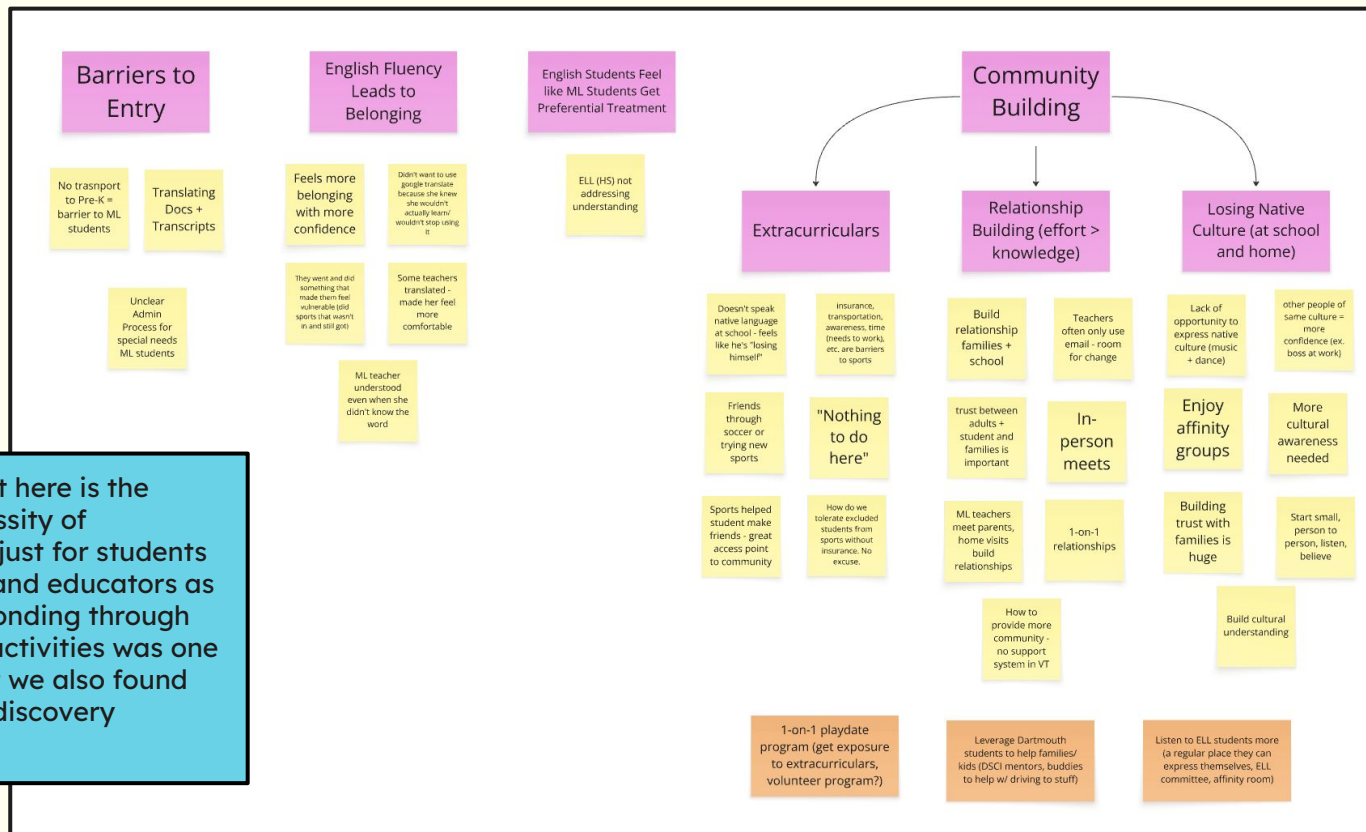
- Sharing the stories we have accumulated through our interviews and research to deepen everyone's understanding of the ELL experience from multiple perspectives, especially those for ELL students and their teachers
- Continuing to gather authentic insights from families, educators, and administrators about what helps new ELL students feel an immediate sense of belonging.
- Co-creating affinity maps with our participants to further develop ideas about how best to approach student belonging.

Together we participated in a gallery walk, reading insights from previous activities written on poster paper hanging around the room, and added thoughts, ideas, and stories to our own clipboards. After, we co-created affinity maps in groups to develop themes in our research and begin discussion potential solutions. We ended with a small group discussion on the activity.

Co-Creation Session 2

Affinity Map pt. 1

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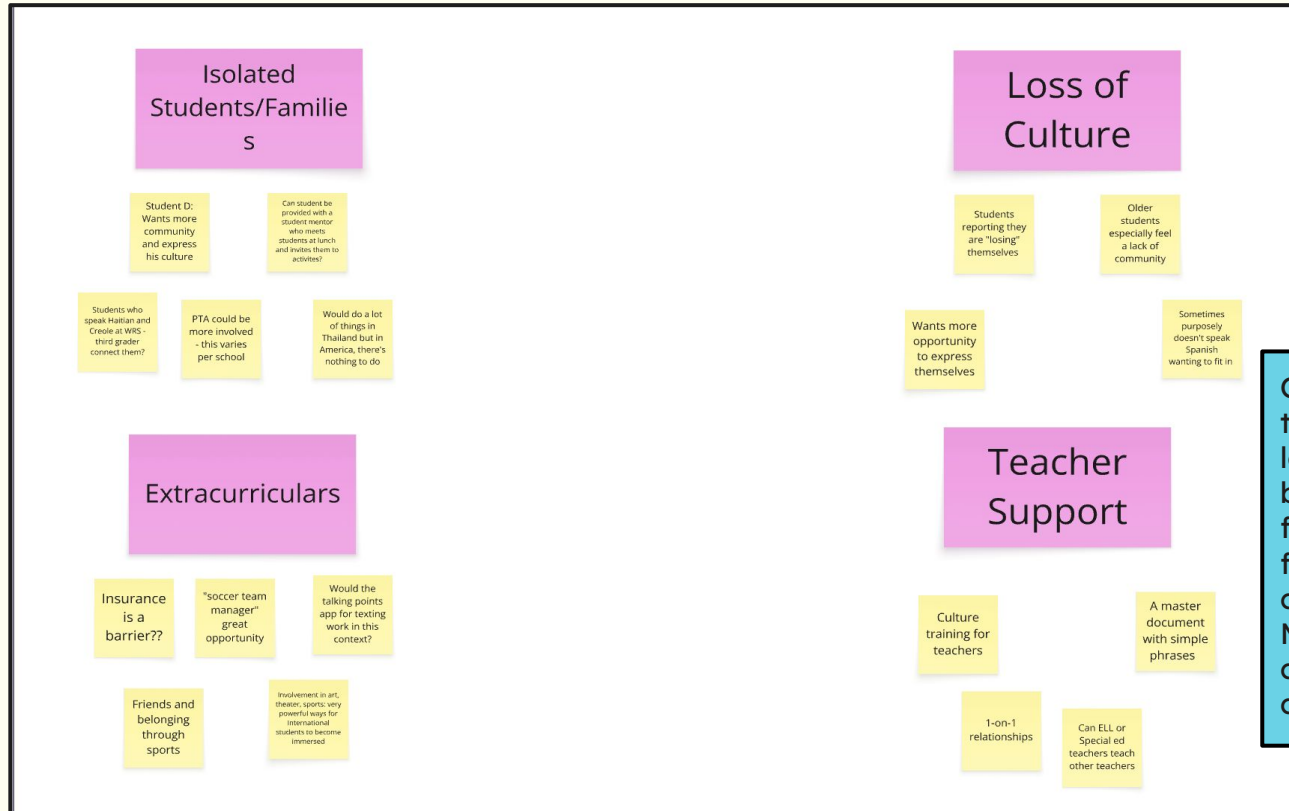


One main insight here is the power and necessity of community, not just for students but for parents and educators as well. Students bonding through extracurricular activities was one insight here that we also found throughout our discovery research.

Co-Creation Session 2

Affinity Map pt. 2

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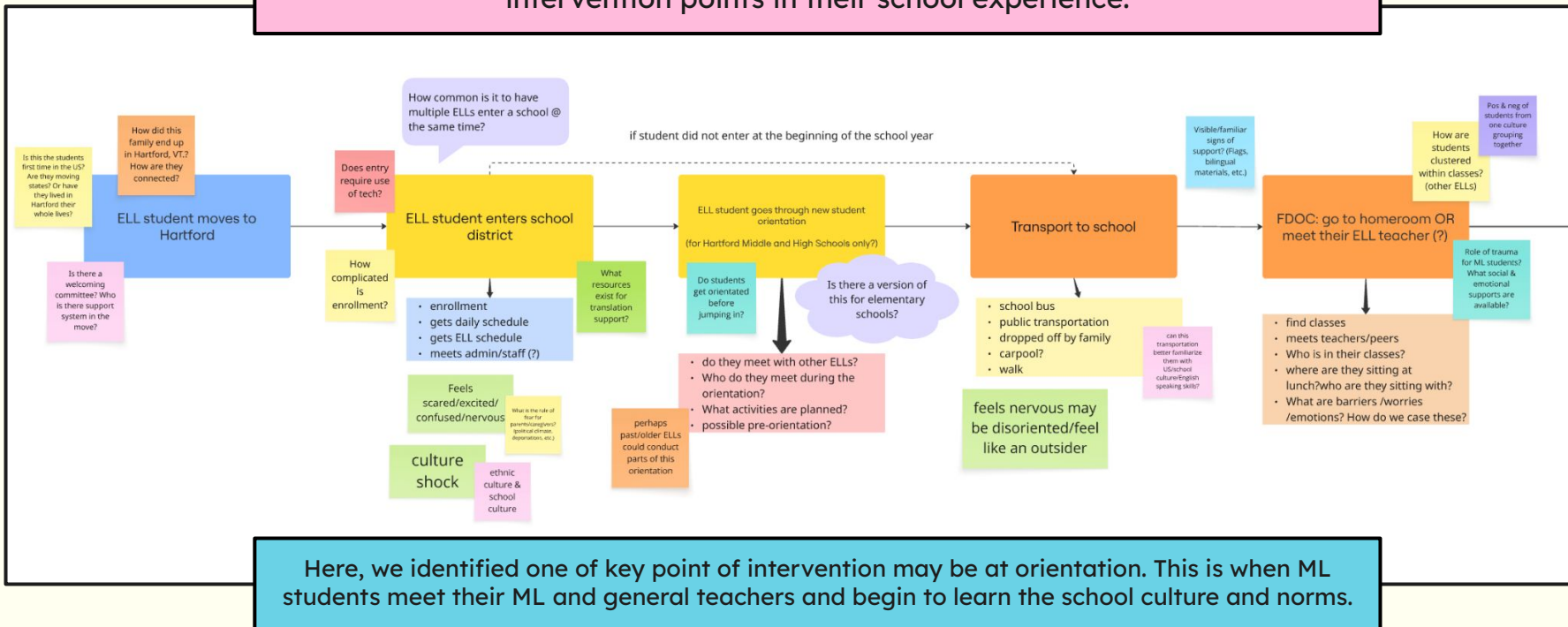


One main insight we got from this portion of the activity is loss of culture and isolation because of cultural differences faced by ML students and families. Foster a sense of community and safety where MLs and their families can feel comfortable expressing their culture is key.

Flowchart Map pt. 1

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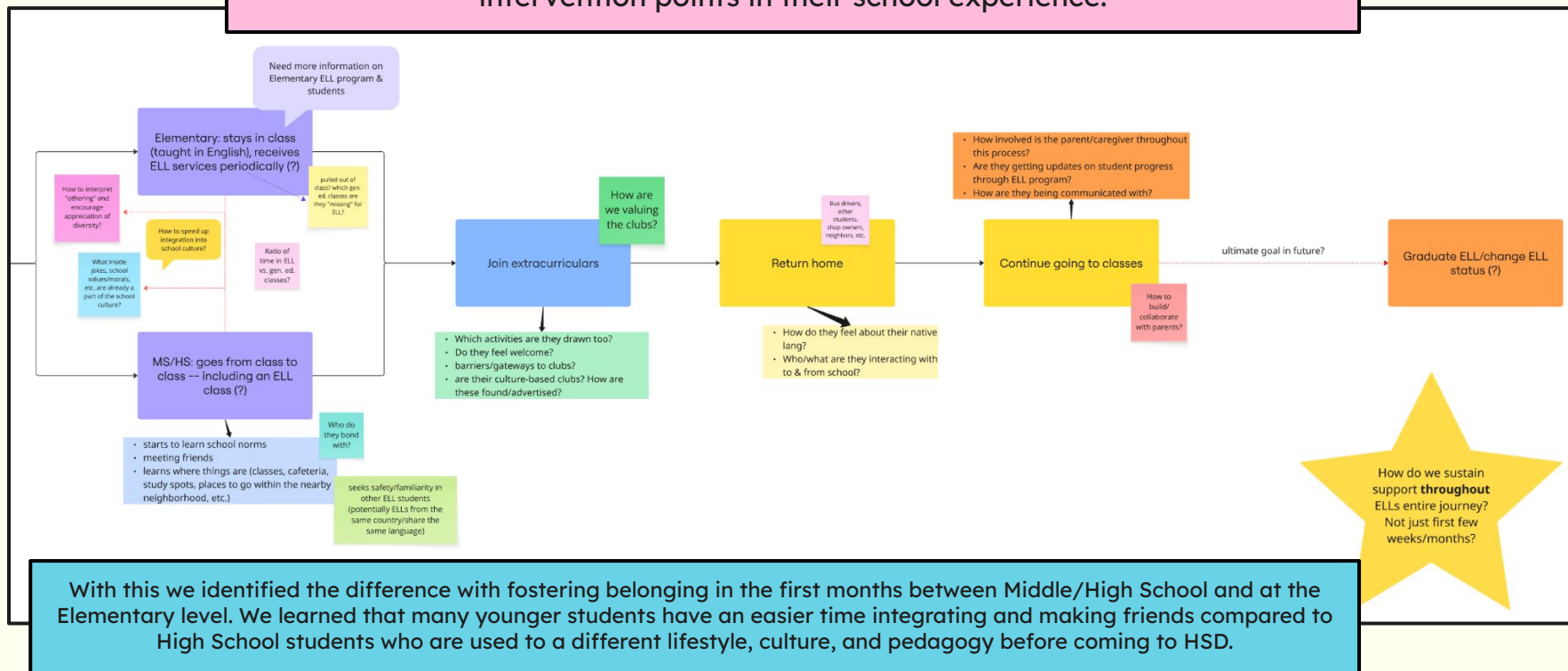
We used a flow chart to map the path a new ELL student takes and possible intervention points in their school experience.



Flowchart Map pt. 2

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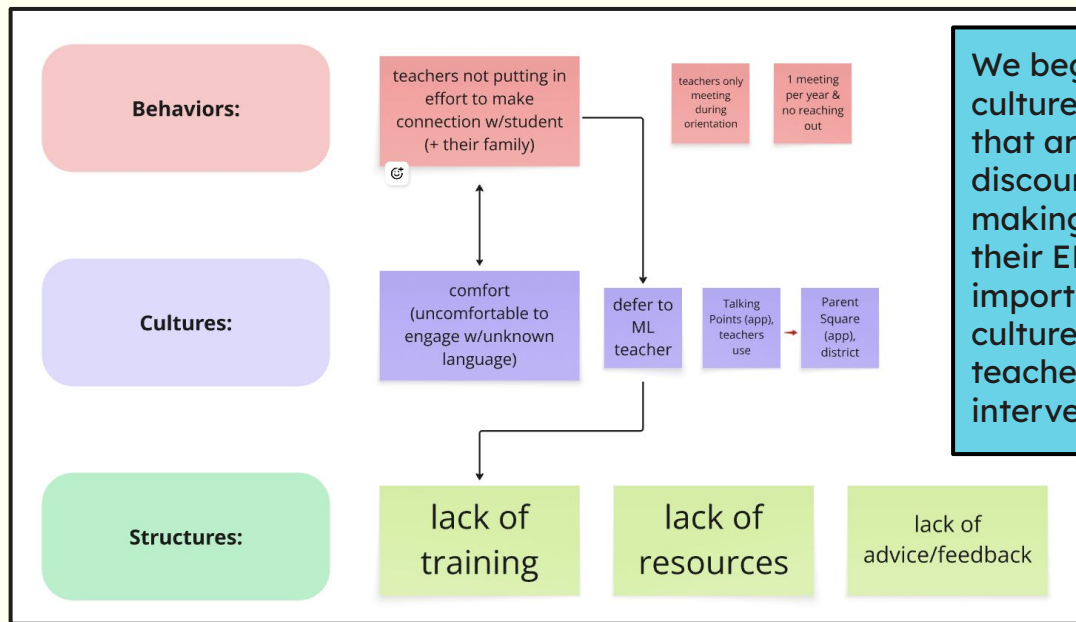
We used a flow chart to map the path a new ELL student takes and possible intervention points in their school experience.



Behaviors, Structures, Cultures Map pt. 1

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We developed behavior, structure, culture maps to understand the distinctions between each in student experiences. This allowed us to understand what cultures might be underneath student or teachers' behaviors and assess what we could do positively impact them.

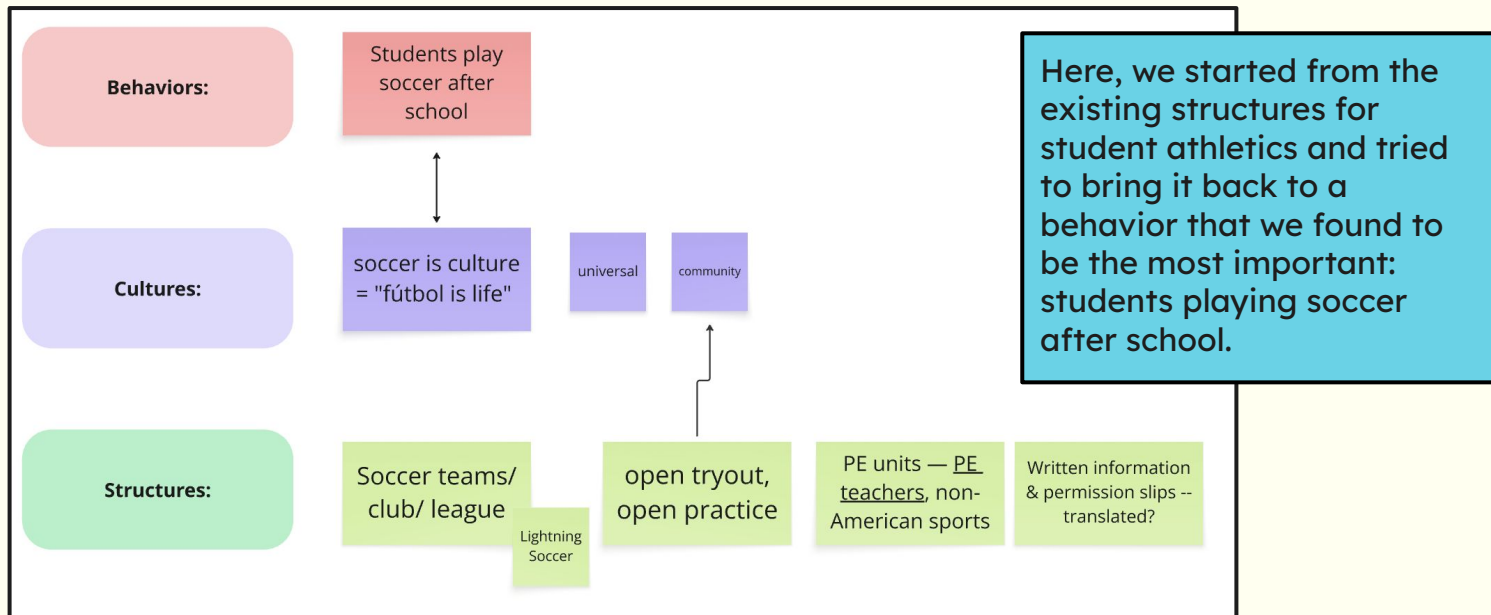


We began to separate out what cultures and structures exist that are potentially discouraging teachers from making an effort to connect to their ELL students. Most importantly, the existing culture of deferring to the ML teacher could be a point of intervention.

Behaviors, Structures, Cultures Map pt. 2

22

We developed behavior, structure, culture maps to understand the distinctions between each in student experiences. This allowed us to understand what cultures might be underneath student or teachers' behaviors and assess what we could do positively impact them.



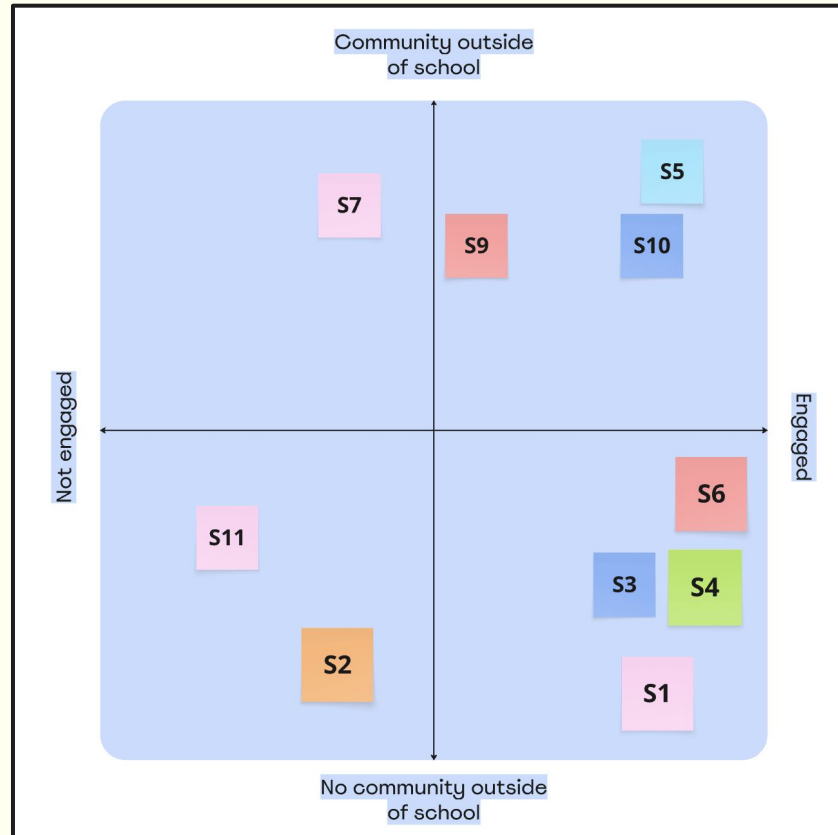
2x2 Personas Map

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We used 2x2 Persona Mapping to understand what group of students we could best design for.

X-axis: engagement with school community, this includes sports, music, and classes.

Y-axis: Community of 1st language speakers outside of school.



In this activity, we identified the students who would be the most isolated: those who are in the lower left quadrant. Designing for these students would likely have the greatest impact, and small differences could create the biggest change in their sense of belonging.

Key Insights

Secondary Research Overview

- **Language development requires 5-7 years:** ELL Students need 5-7 years to develop the academic language proficiency needed to succeed in grade-level courses, yet many programs don't provide adequate long-term support or monitoring beyond initial placement.
- **Multilingual instruction improves outcomes significantly:** Research shows ELL students learn both language and content (math, science, etc.) better when teaching connects English to their native language through glossaries, culturally relevant problem-solving, and validation of diverse solution methods.
- **A whole-school approach is essential:** Rather than isolating ELL support to one teacher or program, all content teachers, administrators, and staff must collaborate on integrating language, literacy, and socio-emotional competencies across all subjects.
- **Motivational and confidence challenges are substantial:** Many ELL Students experience discouragement, anxiety, and stress—particularly international students. Positive reinforcement, safe environments for risk-taking, and culturally responsive teaching are critical interventions.
- **Teacher preparation and professional development are major barrier:** Many educators lack training in sheltered instruction, cultural responsiveness, and multilingual pedagogy; investing in teacher education programs and ongoing PD is more feasible than specialized hiring in resource-constrained districts.
- **Multilingual students benefit other students:** Research shows that ML students improve school communities, create diverse learning environments, and bring a passion for learning.

Main Insights Overview

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Power of sports
(bonding
activities without
language)

People who don't
learn foreign
languages don't
understand the
difficulty and
discomfort of
trying to speak

ELL students
need a way to
feel belonging
while
maintaining their
native language/
culture

Students (and
Parents) need
access to
translated
materials

Existing
systems are
difficult to
navigate for
Non-English
speakers

Teacher effort
matters more
than fluency

Secondary Research Connections to Insights

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Power of sports (bonding activities without language) - Youth sports help students build confidence - Sports increase self-esteem and creativity - Tasked based language learning is more beneficial to students - Sports provide an environment for students to engage with peers outside of the classroom environment	People who don't learn foreign languages don't understand the difficulty and discomfort of trying to speak - The term "Language learning Anxiety" causes many "academic, cognitive, and social effects" - Students can spend their days at school in a constant state of worry over assessments, communication anxiety, and the unknown	ELL students need a way to feel belonging while maintaining their native language/ culture - ML students can provide valuable cultural learning experiences to non-ML students - Formal schooling influences student ideologies and impacts their peer interactions. - Multicultural students can often feel confused or like they've lost a part of themselves
Students (and Parents) need access to translated materials - Hard to translate websites/ online information are a barrier to parent involvement - Breaking the communication barrier between parents and teachers is most effectively done when teachers have immediate translating tools and they have been trained to use them	Existing systems are difficult to navigate for Non-English speakers - After arrival to the US, 30% of immigrant families live below the poverty line meaning that external factors already put pressure on new ELL students - Intentional or unintentional barriers in the enrollment or administrative processes for school enrollment can have negative impacts on students	Teacher effort matters more than fluency Culturally responsive teaching and social-emotional learning integration are essential as teachers should validate diverse cultural backgrounds to help ELL students develop empathy, resilience, and a sense of community

The Power of Sports

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During co-creation session #1:

- Story of a student who wanted to learn ice hockey:
 - She was willing to learn and team was willing to teach her
 - The team helped her acquire all the equipment and figured out how to get her to practice
 - She may never play but she bonded with the team - it is a very positive experience

During student interviews:

- S6 started feeling a sense of belonging when joined lacrosse
 - She initially joined because she thought she should try something new
 - After lacrosse - started being more confident
 - She met best friend through soccer - didn't play this year but was team manager

During stakeholder interviews:

- Stakeholders mentioned that they can see the changes that sports and extracurriculars can have in students sense of belonging, however current barriers (including insurance and transportation) exist

Understanding Discomfort of Language Learning

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During Co-Creation Session #1:

- In VT, not many people speak a language other than English
- People don't know the vulnerability and exhaustion of speaking other people's language
- ML people looked down upon for not knowing English
- Lack of foreign education impacts us

During Student Interviews:

- It was hard to make friends - not everyone understood that student didn't speak English
- Others thought speaking loudly or slowly would make student understand but that wasn't the problem
- Student would often start over-thinking that everything they said in English is going to be wrong

During Stakeholder Interviews:

- Stakeholders cited that the reason that they felt their colleagues were nervous to reach out to parents and families was because of the language barrier
- E7 stated that they wished more teachers had training about ML students so they could better understand how to support them in their language learning

Belonging While Maintaining Culture or Language

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During Co-Creation Session #1:

- There is a lack of diversity within the district which leads to isolation of ML students
- Different foods at lunch and other aspects of culture may “other” ML students

During student Interviews:

- Students felt “displaced” or like they were “losing themselves” as they lost touch with their native culture over time
- Students enjoyed multicultural affinity groups – though noted that in HS combining ML and Pride affinity groups discouraged them from participating
- Some students struggled to find people with their shared cultures at school, others found community in others who shared their native culture
- Students lack opportunities to show their native culture (dance, food, music, etc.)

During Stakeholder Interviews:

- E6 and E5 mentioned a desire to bring more cultural awareness to the school in classrooms or as an event to allow students to share their culture

Access to Translated Materials

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During Co-Creation Session #1:

- Educators mentioned limited resources and knowledge of what materials are actually needed to best support students
- Educators mentioned that the registration process is difficult for families
- Several participants requested more books/ signs/ information to be translated into multiple languages

During Student Interviews:

- Students wished the library had books in their 1st language
- S1 stated carrying a translating tablet was embarrassing
- Students mentioned that it was annoying having to translate materials sent home in English for their parents

During Stakeholder Interviews:

- E4 mentioned that the district website translate button is hard to find and navigate for families
- Educators rely heavily on google translate to quickly convert materials but it is not the most accurate method

Administrative Processes are Difficult

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During Co-Creation #1 and #2:

- Educators believe students with learning disabilities are incorrectly diagnosed because of their ELL status
- Participants mentioned that the enrollment process can be difficult when communicating over email

During Student Interviews:

- Students are unable to access sports because of insurance issues
- S6 is facing difficulty with college counselor and the college process being able to process her non-English transcript

During Stakeholder Interviews:

- Several interviewees stated that the enrollment process was confusing to navigate and they wished documents were translated into several languages
- What helped was being able to be in-person with the families to help them fill it out
- One family moved homes over one weekend because of miscommunications with coordinator

Teacher Effort Over Fluency

During Co-Creation #1:

- Participants wrote that the things that make them the most nervous about having multilingual classrooms are letting them down or feeling like a failure
- Educators are unsure of the “right” thing to do, so they do nothing

During Stakeholder Interviews:

- E10 said that she never had any ELL Students since no teacher would recommend an ELL student to get her services
- Staff want to approach students and make them feel welcomed, but don't know what to say
- E1 sees nervousness to translate or desire to be equitable means no outreach to ML families by teachers

During Student Interviews:

- S2 described how there was no transparency and almost no attempt at communication with her or her family when she first joined the school
- Student S2 said there were three teachers that would lose their patience easily and it scared her

Ideation & Napkin Pitches

Napkin Pitches: Table of Contents

1. Tryout Program: Find Your Team

- a. Description
- b. Rationale
- c. Resources
- d. Next Steps

2. Multicultural Night

- a. Description
- b. Rationale
- c. Resources
- d. Next Steps

3. Peer Mentorship Program

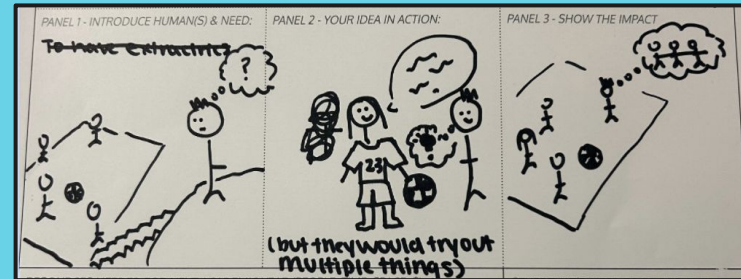
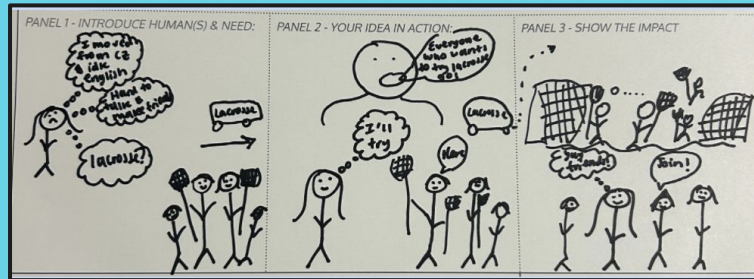
- a. Description
- b. Rationale
- c. Resources
- d. Next Steps

1. Find Your Team Tryout Program

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Description

New tryout program during first few weeks of school - each sports team/dance group/after school activity has an open practice and school provides buses (if necessary) there so students can try it a variety of activities and join what they like. Extra equipment with pamphlets for each activity can be handed out after each practice with images so students can go home and show parents/ guardians. Other additions to the idea: part of PE class or music class for the first week, peer program where ELL student is paired with an English-speaking student or older ML student to get the oriented and bring them to different clubs/ sports, practices/ etc. in their first month.



1. Find Your Team Tryout Program

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Rationale

Notes from interviews and co-creation sessions:

- The story about student learning ice hockey (from sports insight slide)
- The story of ELL student who felt belonging after joining lacrosse and met her best friend by being a soccer manager (from sports insight slide)
- Great way for students to work together without a language barrier - it creates belonging without language learning anxiety (secondary research)
- Student interview: not many places to continue dancing so would be great to get more exposure to the activities around the area
- Reports that athletic participation is very beneficial (co-creation #1 and secondary research)
- Affinity map from co-creation #2 (image to the right)

Extracurriculars

Doesn't speak native language at school - feels like he's "losing himself"

insurance, transportation, awareness, time (needs to work), etc. are barriers to sports

Friends through soccer or trying new sports

"Nothing to do here"

Sports helped student make friends - great access point to community

How do we tolerate excluded students from sports without insurance. No excuse.

1. Find Your Team Tryout Program

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Resources needed

- Participation and enthusiasm from the coaches/ leaders of the teams
- Current players willing to open up the team and welcome new students
- If during school hours, need participation from PE, music, dance, etc. teachers
- ~2 hours/ week --> 2 weeks (then commit to teaching those who join)
- space --> where normally practice
- \$ for equipment, buses, coaches, pamphlets --> ~3k?
- transportation/ carpool system
- Organizer
- Students willing to buddy with an ELL peer

To be designed

- Pamphlets with instructions
- Schedules and details
 - Which activities to incorporate
 - The buddy system for peers
- Advertising
- Permission slips
- Lessons to teach the sport / instrument/ dance
- Program mechanics

1. Find Your Team Tryout Program

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Next steps

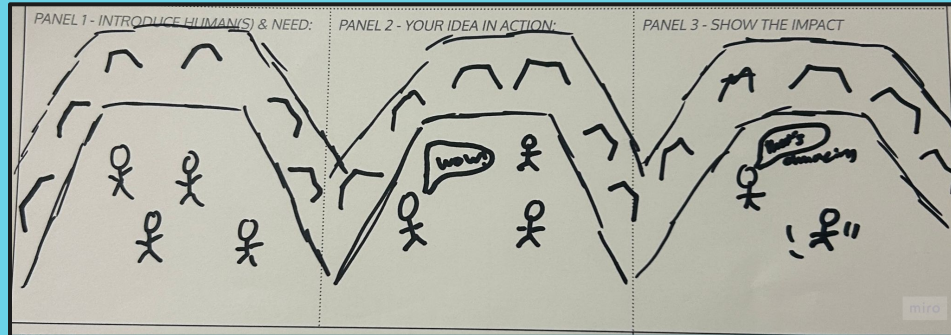
- Send out a survey describing the idea to students to gauge who/how many would sign up
 - Include whether they would be interested in taking on an ELL buddy
- Do a test with 1 sport, 1 band/orchestra, or 1 team or start own team (maybe an interested parent could coach)
 - Organic pilot: can start a new team or program in the winter (maybe ice hockey or figure skating or music)
 - See how many students would join and identify any current obstacles that need to be fixed if planning to continue with idea (fail a lot and quickly to make the program a success!)
 - Can pilot with new non-ML students - this can be a cool team building activity for everyone at school
- Encourage current ELL students to join - either sport, dance, or musical group
- Survey parents/ guardians about the idea
- Overall future metric: teachers should observe if ELL students become more confident in class/ talk to more students
- For future consideration: how do we predict how long student will be active for? Will coaches be less willing to participate if students quit shortly after? Will new students be overwhelmed by so many tryouts and people? What if the buddies don't get along? Should there be a weekly check in?

2. Multicultural Night

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Description

Multicultural Night is a community celebration where families are encouraged to share their ethnic and cultural backgrounds through interactive stations. This could be organized per school or town-wide to celebrate the rich diversity within the greater Hartford community. Every family will be encouraged to set up a station where they share traditional food, clothes, language, and dances with attendees. Stations might include language learning corners where community members can learn basic phrases, try on traditional clothing, sample authentic cuisine, and participate in cultural dances or music. Families could also display cultural artifacts, photographs, or share the stories and histories behind their traditions.



2. Multicultural Night

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Rationale

Notes from interviews and co-creation sessions:

Through interviews with stakeholders and students, one of the biggest topics that came up was lack of cultural awareness. Additionally many ELL students felt a lack of pride to share their cultural backgrounds as they were more concerned about fitting in.

The event also facilitates meaningful peer interactions between ELL students and native English speakers in a celebratory, low-pressure context. Research shows structured, positive interactions accelerate language development and social integration. Additionally, inviting families to take leadership roles acknowledges the importance of culturally respectful communication and meaningful family engagement, which are critical components of effective ELL support systems.

Losing Native
Culture (at school
and home)

Lack of
opportunity to
express native
culture (music
+ dance)

other people of
same culture =
more
confidence (ex.
boss at work)

Enjoy
affinity
groups

More
cultural
awareness
needed

Building
trust with
families is
huge

Start small,
person to
person, listen,
believe

Build cultural
understanding

2. Multicultural Night



Resources Needed:

- Diverse families willing to set up cultural stations and share traditions
- Volunteer coordinators to organize logistics and family outreach
- Space (cafeteria, gymnasium, or outdoor area) large enough for multiple stations
- Budget for supplies, decorations, signage, and basic refreshments (~\$2-5k depending on scope)
- Marketing and promotion across school and community channels
- Interpreters or bilingual staff to facilitate communication and welcome families
- Students willing to help staff stations, translate, and welcome peers

Things to be Designed:

- Detailed planning guide and timeline for organization
- Family invitation letters in multiple languages
- Sign-up forms for families interested in hosting stations
- Station setup templates (what to include: food, clothing, language, dances, artifacts)
- Advertising materials (posters, social media, announcements)
- Program schedule and station map
- Student volunteer recruitment and training materials
- Buddy system pairing ELL and native English-speaking students
- Post-event feedback survey

2. Multicultural Night

Next Steps

1. **Form a planning committee and establish timeline/budget** — Assemble key stakeholders (administrators, ELL coordinators, family liaisons, teachers) to determine event date, secure ~\$2-5k funding, and create a project timeline.
2. **Conduct family outreach and create multilingual materials** — Survey ELL families about interest and barriers, then design invitations and promotions in primary community languages explaining participation expectations.
3. **Develop station guidelines and recruit volunteers** — Create templates for cultural stations and identify student volunteers (both ELL and native English speakers) to help staff and facilitate peer interactions.
4. **Secure logistics and prepare administrative documents** — Secure venue, arrange transportation, and develop permission slips, liability forms, program schedule, and station map.
5. **Implement peer buddy system and conduct training** — Pair ELL students with native English-speaking peers and train all volunteers on cultural sensitivity and engagement strategies.
6. **Finalize promotion and event preparation** — Complete marketing materials in multiple languages and confirm final details with all participating families.
7. **Execute event and gather feedback** — Hold Multicultural Night and distribute post-event surveys to evaluate impact and identify improvements for future years.

2. Multicultural Night

Possible Challenges

Because this project is taking place in a more rural, culturally homogeneous community with a smaller and more dispersed ELL population, shaping the event in a way that is not overwhelming or isolating is important. The design of this event must intentionally welcome all families and foster meaningful connections between ELL students and families with non-ELL families and peers in a celebratory and low-pressure environment.

Additionally, this should be a learning environment, inviting families to acknowledge the cultural diversity in their schools and celebrate it. This event will be a shared cultural exploration rather than a showcase of specific ELL families – inviting all families to contribute something meaningful, i.e. a recipe, tradition, story, etc.

3. Peer Mentor Program

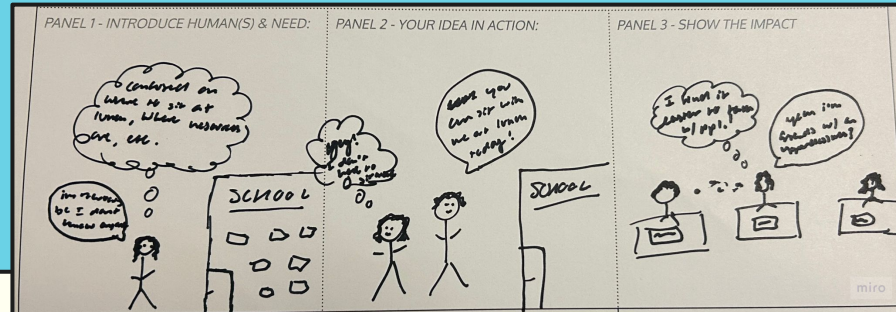
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Description

A volunteer-based program that recruits upperclassmen HSD students, community members, or Dartmouth students to “mentor” incoming ELL students of the same cultural background or who speak the same language.

Students get paired with their mentor. If the mentor is school-specific, mentor/mentees can eat lunch together on the first day, get shown around school, explore new extracurriculars, etc.

For out-of-school mentors, mentors can help transport mentees to sports practices, help with homework, get coffee together, attend shows/games, or simply be someone to talk to about their shared culture/language.



3. Peer Mentor Program

Rationale

This program addresses the lack of culture that ML students feel when they move to Hartford and can make them feel more at ease, less “othered”, and reduce culture loss.

Notes from interviews:

- Students feel like they're losing themselves and feel disconnected from their culture
- Students have no one to talk to in their native language
- Administrators notice that ELLs feel uncomfortable not knowing anyone when they enter the school
- Teachers identify the lack of diversity in Hartford as a barrier to ML student experiences
- Students, teachers, and administrators identify 1-on-1 relationships as the most impactful
- Students and teachers identify trust a crucial component to a good relationship
 - ELL teacher recalls accompanying student at pick up/drop offs, attending sports games, and reaching out over email to check in on student as ways to build trust
- ELL teachers feel overly-responsible to issues regarding ELL students

3. Peer Mentor Program

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Resources needed:

- A group of diverse, enthusiastic volunteers (within-school or community-based) who want to help ELL students
- Small funds for pair outings (coffees, gas money, etc.)
- Or funds for a larger program-wide trip or dinner
- Staff oversight of the program

*Potentially takes away some of resources needed for ELL teachers by spreading the responsibility

To be designed:

- Mentor "trainings" and structure for how to engage with students
- A pairing system
- A system to instill trust in volunteers

3. Peer Mentor Program

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Next Steps

- A form surveying volunteer interest in the program
- A small pilot version for 2-3 existing ELL students to test student engagement and effectiveness in the program
- A pilot with new students (even if non-ML) to test integration into new school
- A 3-6 month "watch" program --> constant check-ins by program lead to test mergers
- An end of year survey on whether can be improved upon and what worked

Contact List

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Thank You



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Please stay in touch!